

TITLE. Say it, let it sit. Do not flip it yet – that is item 3.



ITEM 1, part one (of 2:30 total for items 1). Who is talking. History, and education – NOT meaning schools and universities. The field. The lab. Nerd Nites. Keep it short; the credential reading is the failure mode here and the room did not ask for a career.



ITEM 1, part two. The turn in the introduction. Everything just listed is a sampling of one trajectory. Everyone in this room has a rich history of their own, and tonight those trajectories crossed. END ON: *Thank you.* Grateful to all who want to share, all who facilitate, all who come to experience. Let the thank-you land before moving.

ITEM 2, 0:45. The outline, in four words, delivered fast. Do not expand any of them. The point of this slide is that it will make sense in retrospect, not now.

ITEM 3, 1:30. The flip, and the thesis. What people say when a story dies on retelling – the apology you make when the telling failed. Turn it over: tonight it is not an apology, it is the condition. NEEDS FROM HIM: the opening twenty seconds, an instance of the phrase actually failing. Still open as of 12 Oct.



ITEM 4a, 2:30. Hannah Bauer, "Worst Party Ever: Everything You Didn't Know About the Donner Party." NNFC S2025E01, 30 Jan 2025. WHAT SHE DID: took a genuinely horrible situation and made it funny by putting the room, momentarily, into the mindset of the people involved. Her own hook does this talk's flip three years early: most people hear Donner Party and think cannibalism – valid, but that only scratches the surface. Nobody in that bar was in the Sierra Nevada in 1846. For a moment they were. Do not explain why that matters. It gets explained at Mars.

ITEM 4b, 0:30. Read the title aloud. Stop. Add nothing. It is already funnier than any gloss. FIRST CUT IF RUNNING LONG – this whole frame is 30 seconds and it is the only genuinely optional beat in the talk.

ITEM 5, 0:45. THE HINGE. Name the recursion out loud, as the joke it is. You were not at any of those. Often the speaker was not at the thing either – Berlioz has been dead since 1869. So a talk called You Had to be There has just spent three minutes on second- and third-hand material, and it worked. *** ASK THE QUESTION AND DO NOT ANSWER IT. *** If the why gets resolved here, Mars becomes a restatement and the middle of the talk goes flat for two minutes. Ask, pause, move. NEEDS FROM HIM: exact wording, which must not contain its own answer.



ITEM 6a. We have not sent people to Mars. We have sent probes, rovers, instruments, and they have returned more data than anyone can read. Somebody had a hypothesis before that thing ever launched. Somebody else has a model in their head while reading what came back. Neither is in the data stream.

ITEM 6b. The thesis as mechanism, said once, flat. It is where the people are that the cognition happens. Do not say the word "cognition" twice and do not elaborate. Next beat.



ITEM 7, 1:30. John Anderson, "Worm Majix." NNFC S2025E08, 18 Sep 2025. Long-time friend of Wolverine Farm who used to watch the Nerd Nite crowd assemble. Approached Senne one evening, was soon on the calendar. The abstract arrived rough and hard to follow. Jamie started to edit it. I stopped her. We ran it exactly as offered. REASON, ONE LINE, PAST TENSE: we want to platform people who want to talk – to connect speakers and audience, not filter them. Then John on stage, dressed as he dresses for any other evening at the Wolverine, speaking as himself. Great talk. *** DO NOT READ HIS ABSTRACT ALOUD. *** That makes John the joke in front of other bosses. The beat needs the decision, not the exhibit. WHY IT IS HERE: Mars invites the response "so transmit better." This is the counter-example. The edit that would have made it clearer would have removed John from it. The version that read worse carried the person. OPTIONAL, ONE SENTENCE, HIS CALL: same mechanism as the HoloLens spec bug – a legible restatement silently becomes the reference.



ITEM 8a. Joel Bacon, "Let's Build a Pipe Organ!" NNFC S2026E06, 18 Jun 2026. As he talked through the parts – wind supply, keys, pipes – his assistants and THE AUDIENCE assembled hundreds of them into a working two-octave, hand-pumped, mechanical-action pipe organ.



ITEM 8b. THE LANDING. The only moment of real feeling in the talk. Joel is a professor, a composer, a working musician. He sat down and brought it to life. SAY ONCE, FLAT, THEN STOP: it connected me to the music in a way I had never felt before. *** NO SECOND SENTENCE. *** The explanation is the sentimentality that kills it. The pause does the work. *** DO NOT GENERALISE. *** Not "and that's what Nerd Nite does." No instruction to the room, not once. THE VOLUNTEER: that organ is hand pumped. It cannot make a sound unless a person is standing there supplying the air. We needed a volunteer. Somebody put their hand up. Say "a volunteer," not "an audience member." Mars inverted: there the instrument goes and the people stay home, and the chronicle comes back incomplete. Here the people built the instrument and stayed in the room. Same notes. Same physics. Identical data.

ITEM 9, 0:30. THE CLOSE. Screen is deliberately empty – no slide does this for you, and a slide reading "You are." would rob it. NEEDS FROM HIM: the twenty seconds before the turn. Carry the room from the organ to stillness. THEN: You had to be there. You are. NOTHING AFTER IT. No thank-you inside the talk (that was item 1), no call to action, no "next time you're at a show." Stop talking.